Only, the timing went horribly wrong. The scars of the 26/11 terror attack in Mumbai had not healed and the Maharashtra assembly elections were just months away. The prime minister may have wanted a place in history; his party had an eye on the polls. Instead of backing him, they decided to criticize the move. Manish Tewari, who was Congress spokesperson at the time, recalled how he was sent an SMS from a senior party leader asking him to leave midway through a TV programme with former diplomats, and stop defending the government. Another spokesperson, Abhishek Singhvi, received similar orders.

'I think that's the moment the prime minister just switched off,' fears Tewari. If the party and Sonia would no longer back him to take tough decisions, then he felt it just wasn't worth it any longer. The same party leadership that had endorsed him on the Indo-US nuclear deal had now turned against him. Dr Singh had just had a major bypass surgery in January and his health was only gradually recovering—Sharm el-Sheikh set him back once again. He would never really recover. A senior member of the Congress Working Committee (CWC) confirmed to me that in his second term there were at least four separate occasions when Dr Singh offered to resign.

It was not just Sharm el-Sheikh. Whenever the government was in a crisis—be it the Anna agitation or the 2G scam—Dr Singh felt the party did not defend him vigorously enough. Sonia did make periodic statements in support of her chosen prime minister. For example, when the telecom scam broke, her first reaction was, 'It is shameful that a person of the integrity of the prime minister should be targeted in this manner. Everyone knows the prime minister is 100 per cent above board.' Somehow, though, her words lacked the confidence she had shown when she stood by him on the Indo-US nuclear deal.

Indeed, Sonia's own role in UPA-II's critical years between 2009 and 2011 is questionable. A good example of her political instincts failing her was the manner in which she dealt with the aftermath of the sudden death of Andhra Pradesh chief minister Y.S. Rajasekhar Reddy in September 2009 in a helicopter accident. A powerful regional satrap who had brought the